On many nights I didn't understand most of what was taking place or being said onstage. But when I did understand, worse for me. The words burned. They troubled. Why would I want to hear about a grief-stricken kingdom "contracted in one brow of woe"? That just put me in mind of August 1997. Why would I want to meditate upon the inalterable fact that "all that lives must die, passing through nature to eternity…"? I had no time to think about eternity.

The one piece of literature I remember enjoying, even savoring, was a slender American novel. *Of Mice and Men* by John Steinbeck. We were assigned it in our English divs.

Unlike Shakespeare, Steinbeck didn't need a translator. He wrote in plain, simple vernacular. Better yet, he kept it tight. *Of Mice and Men*: a brisk 150 pages.

Best of all, its plot was diverting. Two blokes, George and Lennie, gadding about California, looking for a place to call their own, trying to overcome their limitations. Neither's a genius, but Lennie's trouble seems to be more than low IQ. He keeps a dead mouse in his pocket, strokes it with his thumb—for comfort. He also loves a puppy so much that he kills it.

A story about friendship, about brotherhood, about loyalty, it was filled with themes I found relatable. George and Lennie put me in mind of Willy and me. Two pals, two nomads, going through the same things, watching each other's back. As Steinbeck has one character say: "A guy needs somebody—to be near him. A guy goes nuts if he ain't got nobody."

So true. I wanted to share it with Willy.

Too bad he was still pretending not to know me.

21.

MUST'VE BEEN EARLY spring, 1999. I must've been home from Eton for the weekend.

I woke to find Pa on the edge of my bed, saying I was going back to Africa.

Africa, Pa?

Yes, darling boy.

Why?